Museu do Resgate (Museum of Ransom): can everyday videos proclaim documental and patrimonial values?

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http://www.museudoresgate.org

Abstract: In this paper we present the project "Museu do Resgate" (Museum of Ransom), which has been developed within the PhD program in digital media at the University of Porto. Initiated in June 2012, this project's mission is to gather on a website (www.museudoresgate.org) different views on everyday local cultures, recorded on video. The main objective is to contribute to the discussion, identified in an early stage of the investigation, about a new museum concept, which seems to be growing online, the "museum of all". This is being built collectively and emerges from the proliferation of new tools for creating and sharing digital content online, used by many people to document their daily lives.

Our research project aims to contribute to the reading of the emerging concepts of "documentary". We seek to understand how digital media can contribute, through its strongly ubiquitous, social and participatory characteristics, to the inclusion of citizens in documentary practice. Consequently, we seek to understand the documental and patrimonial value of everyday videos.

The practical project was launched with the support of the City Council's cultural program "Manobras no Porto", that during 2011 and 2012, aimed at encouraging and financing projects that wanted to explore their interactions with local communities in the Historical Center of Porto.

Given the inclusive nature of our project and the importance of citizens' natural and spontaneous participation, we adopted a set of diverse research methods with exploratory and ethnographic characteristics. Therefore, in this paper, we will expose the methodological approach as well as reveal the difficulties, surprises and opportunities that we found in the course of the implemented actions.

Finally, we present a set of preliminary conclusions, explain what will be our main contribution to the research area and propose an overview on future developments.

Keywords: daily life, local cultures, documental heritage, participatory visions, audiovisual documents, Museum of All

New ecosystem of audiovisual consumption

The research project that this paper refers to, arises from the suspicion that the concept of documental subject may be experiencing profound changes, facing the reality of the society of media consumption that has become increasingly participatory.

In fact, the participatory media[1] have been recognized as responsible for a large number of changes in traditional media ecosystem. The production, sharing and consumption of media content are increasingly available to anyone. In this age of 'consumer-generated content', we have been witnessing the emancipation of the passive consumer individual, who can now very easily become an active producer individual. This means the emancipation of the individual, not only in the consumption chain of media content, but also in relation to the great political, economic and social organizations. Now, this individual no longer depends on these organizations to structure his participation in society, or to communicate with other individuals.

[1] By participatory media we mean the set of online and offline processes that have been introducing the participation feature in the ecosystem of producing, broadcasting and consuming of media contents.

After nearly a century consuming media content through a unidirectional configuration, in this new century, people are looking for alternative ways of consuming media content. During the twentieth century, people had access to cultural production through mass media such as radio and television. Today, with the internet, many people have swapped the radio with online music consuming websites, and more and more people are swapping the television with online video sharing websites, where most of the contents are user-generated. Indeed, we have been observing an increase in the amount of new audiences consuming audiovisual content on online platforms such as YouTube, instead of doing it on television, as past generations used to do (Strangelove 2011).

Unlike what happened in that medium of unidirectional structure (TV), on YouTube, most of the content that people consume are produced by individuals with a lack of academic or professional qualifications in the audiovisual area. According to Michael Strangelove (Strangelove 2011), the great abundance of spectators in YouTube is due to the user-generated feature and, among many other things, this topic has been marking the difference between YouTube and television, as a means for consuming audiovisual contents.

YouTube users make use of the more common video recording tools — from camcorders to mobile phones — and the increasingly accessible video editing tools, as 'weapons' for representation and expression. These digital tools enable the construction of a personal view, and share it with other users and members of a group or a community, something unimaginable in a medium like television. And we believe that the social stimuli of sharing, cooperation and collective action have been continually encouraging the growth of the people's willingness to engage in the media content ecosystem. It is the desire to achieve the viewer's credit or even a viral fame on the Internet, which continues to promote the production and sharing of audiovisual content on platforms such as YouTube.

The audiovisual documentation of daily life as heritage

Among the wide variety of types and categories of amateur videos that can be found on YouTube, we want to focus our argument on those, which, in one way or another, can contribute to documenting the everyday life of local cultures. The subject can be personal, family, a group, a community or a population. Some of these videos work even as unique views of events, which otherwise would not have such instantaneous and factual cover. Despite being unstructured and dispersed on platforms like YouTube, these documents present the potential to contribute significantly to the preservation of an intangible cultural heritage of societies.

The recordings of cultural heritage of groups, communities and civilizations have been a major area of interest to linguists, anthropologists, ethnologists and sociologists since the early nineteenth century. Several investigators, armed with new skills, tools and practices have been recording habits, traditions and cultural expressions endangered, over almost two centuries. In the early twentieth century, the international agency UNESCO adopted a convention (UNESCO 2003), concerning the safeguarding of intangible cultural heritage. However, this convention has raised a discussion among several scholars from anthropology and sociology. Some argue that it was a victory for anthropology, since this was the first time there was an explicit concern with the intangible heritage of local cultures in an official document produced by an international agency. Others argue that this convention only came to confirm a political vision on this theme, filled with a great contradiction. It seems to adopt a globalized vision in relation to the concept of cultural heritage. Manuel João Ramos, a Portuguese anthropologist, suggests that it is a "mental colonization of a variety of cultures in a way that contradicts the intention of preserving cultural diversity" (TSF 2009).[2]

According to what is described by UNESCO in its convention (UNESCO 2003), intangible heritage is something alive, dynamic, and constantly changing. Therefore, its protection, preservation and consequent "crystallization" is something that in certain situations may not make any sense. Take the case of traditions with which local communities have no longer any connection or identification, or where procedures and work techniques became obsolete facing the technological evolution, or the case of the establishment of new rigid spelling rules that can endanger the natural evolution of a language.

Therefore we believe that, given its diversity and uniqueness, we cannot pretend to describe a particular local culture through globalizing processes, provided with a single homogenized perspective,

[2] Translated by the author of this paper from Portuguese to English. The original quote in Portuguese is: "colonização mental de uma série de culturas que, de certa maneira, contradiz a intenção preservadora da diversidade cultural".

which will only contribute to a cultural uniformity. We must not apply the methods of classification of material heritage to examples of intangible heritage. In fact, the process of safeguarding intangible cultural heritage has been delegated to officially recognized organizations, such as the research centers in anthropology and sociology (linked to universities) and museums, which have the mission to document, collect, preserve and present representative elements of the expressiveness of local culture. The judgment on what kind of and which objects or subjects may have heritage value has been the responsibility of an elected set of experts. They have been the ones who decide what is or is not provided with patrimonial vocation.

However, if culture is something that concerns the individuals, members of a group, a community, a population or a civilization, as stated in the convention, who better than these individuals to decide themselves what should or should not be preserve in their own culture? More important than deciding what should be preserved and how it should be preserved, is to include citizens in the decision making process. We believe that by engaging citizens in this process, making it participatory, we will strengthen the social fabric, the values of citizenship and the very authenticity of what is preserved. Above all, we will be then safeguarding the whole process against confinement to political, commercial and/or tourism interests.

Thus, in our research we question what may be the contribution of participatory media in this process of recognition of heritage value. In other words, how can the participatory media contribute to the inclusion of citizens in documentary practice and thus make that the safeguarding of intangible cultural heritage a collective action, ceasing to be allocated only to official institutions? In this context, what can be the role of audiovisual amateur recordings of everyday lives? What is their heritage value?

If we look again at what is going on YouTube, we realize that people are instinctively contributing to a documentary recording of certain aspects of their culture, or how they see the world. Although scattered and unstructured, these recordings seem to be part of an audiovisual archive of everyday life. This archive, if gathered, structured and interpreted, may resemble a kind of living museum, built collectively, not only by those who visit and use it, but also by all those who actively contribute to it. We believe that our research project may contribute to the discussion about the concept of a ‘museum of all’ through its practical project, the “Museu do Resgate” (Museum of Ransom), opened in 2012.

The work phases and their methodology

The research project within which was developed the Museum of Ransom, began long before 2012. In fact, for a better understanding of the research methods that we used, it is important to understand the five phases of the research project.

The first phase, developed under the Masters degree (Brandão 2008) served as the starting point for all further research work. In 2008, we developed a set of four exploratory exercises involving the Serralves Foundation in Porto and its Museum of Contemporary Art. These exercises aimed at understanding the results of the participation of the museum’s visitors in the construction, reconstruction and deconstruction of their own institutional identity, using video as a tool.

In a second phase, already under the PhD degree, there was the need to deepen the approach to the concept of participatory museum, or, more precisely, the ‘museum of all’. After surveying a set of hypotheses of territories to continue the work and after reformulating the initial questions, we realized the need to distance ourselves from the traditional territory of the institutions. Then the Manobras no Porto, a cultural intervention program centered on the geographic territory of the Historical Center of Porto, emerged as a good opportunity to start a project where we could test our assumptions and seek answers to our research questions. So, the main objective was to build a collective audiovisual repertoire. The mission of Manobras no Porto was to involve citizens in the construction of their own cultural activities and thus, identities. This mission of inclusion was the major reason that reinforced the suitability of this program as a territory to develop our case study.

It is important to mention that we realized early on that the methodological approach best suited to the objectives of our research, that needed be taken from this phase onwards, was the action-research model or auscultate-propose. This is an approach within which, after a phase of exploratory and empirical work of observation and data collection, we would present practical exercises that explore contexts of participation and collaboration.

Consequently, in the second phase of this research, in 2011, we developed a preliminary and exploratory work where we studied the subject and its territory of action, the program Manobras no Porto. It was then that we adopted an intuitive methodology, which involved the use of participant

observation during the Manobras no Porto activities, the implementation of a set of exploratory interviews to various cultural activists of Porto and others involved with the program, and the development of short participatory audiovisual exercises. This phase allowed the testing of some experiments, and also the reading of the potential feedback that people can give when they are asked to express their own views on their street or town.

At the beginning of the year 2012, after the identification and characterization of the territory of action, the opportunity arose to propose a practical project that could pronounce our research intentions and test the hypotheses. In June of the same year we launched the project Museum of Ransom, a website with the aim of bringing together the recordings of everyday at the Historical Center of Porto, conducted by its inhabitants, visitors and people who work there. Recordings made without aesthetic challenges that could be conducted using any type of equipment that create video. Recordings made by anyone with any talent for video making.

Image 1: Submission form at the Museum of Ransom website.

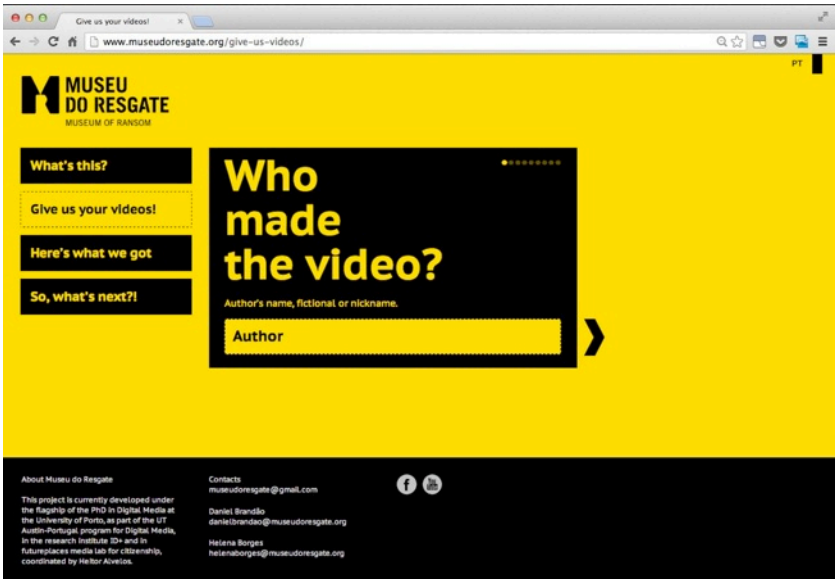
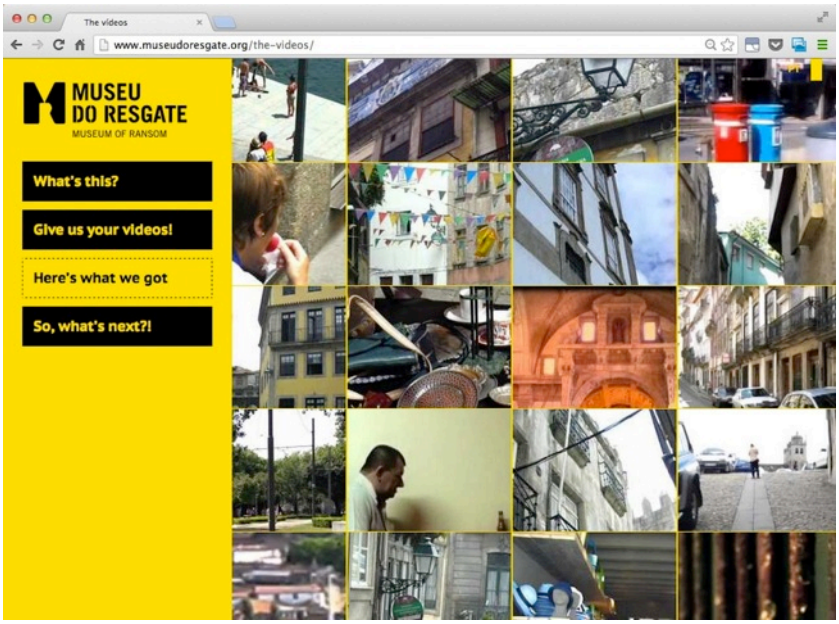


Image 2: Grid of rescued videos at the Museum of Ransom website.



Print screens from the Museum of Ransom website.

The third phase of the research was, mostly, about the construction of the website, to the aggregation of all the collected videos. This website is divided into three areas: an area where the user can get to know more about the project and its mission, an area asking for contributions via a submission form (image 1), and a third area where the user can access all rescued videos (image 2). In this phase, we designed a visual and communication strategy, where we opted to adopt very direct, honest and simple language, as we believed that the project should be understood easily.

During the construction of the website, we also started the fourth phase of work, the main objective - through direct contact with the people of the historical center of Porto – was to communicate the project, recruit regular contributors and present results. We collected videos that were already made, house by house, and planned weekly recording sessions, which we called 'raids' (image 3). Participants, mainly from outside the historical center of Porto, were invited to submit their views through pathways or oriented by a set of previously announced topics of interest. The outcomes were presented through video projection at local establishments such as pubs, cafes and restaurants and also in debate sessions, included in the program of Manobras no Porto.

For the logistical support in the fieldwork and the programming and implementation of the website, two people were recruited. All the actions taken were documented in photographs and videos. And all the episodes, conversations and contacts that we made with people involved in the project were recorded in a field diary. These techniques allowed the entire work process and its results to be subject to regular review throughout the development of the project. Thus, some of the initial expectations had to be reshaped and adapted to the surprises, obstacles, difficulties and opportunities that were being found.

Image 3: Video raid at a local barber shop.



Mr Adão filming at Mr Agostinho's barber shop.

In the fifth phase of the research project, already underway, we intend to expand the Museum of Ransom to other sites, territories and contexts. We have already developed a workshop during the digital media festival "futureplaces"[3] as well as partnerships with other academic projects: one on the theme of Porto's gastronomy, another one on the memories of one street in a small town at north of

[3] The "futureplaces" website can be consulted online at: http://www.futureplaces.org.

Porto and another one on the assemblage of the audiovisual repertoire of the bands and musicians who rehearse in the old shopping center STOP, also in Porto.

Conclusions and future work

This last phase of the project will also involve the restructuring of the website, which will include a set of recommendations on how to implement a new 'Ransom'. The user, or visitor of this 'metaphorical museum', will be able to contribute with his own videos, provide new interpretations of the existing archive (through the assembly of new audiovisual narratives), and even submit proposals for curating new application contexts for the project. So what was developed in the historical center of Porto will thus be one of many possible applications of the ideology and actions of the Museum of Ransom. It is thus our intention to open the project to new uses and interpretations, in order to contribute to the development of a critical awareness of the importance of the documenting process in the creation of a collective visual memory of local cultures, and of the heritage potential of everyday amateur audiovisual recordings.

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